

Research Statement

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My research asks how migration shapes economic mobility. I look at natural experiments from large-scale historical shocks to analyze how people make economic choices under pressure. Understanding these choices provides a framework for designing modern place-based policies and helping people adapt to economic change.

My job market paper uses the WWII internment of Japanese Americans as one such natural experiment in forced migration. Using a newly-available linked census dataset (IPUMS MLP), I track individuals' locations and wages from 1940 to 1950. Unlike previous studies, this linked data approach allows me to follow individuals instead of relying on group-level data, and also allows me to control for pre-internment incomes in my analysis. I employ a difference-in-differences framework, comparing Japanese Americans to a control group of Chinese Americans, to estimate the causal effect of internment on later economic outcomes. My results show that forced removal from the West Coast paradoxically increased internees' 1950 incomes by approximately 20% on average, conditional on pre-war earnings. This effect appears to be driven in part by internees relocating to higher-wage regions outside the West Coast after the war, as well as by internee women increasing their participation in wage-earning labor. I test alternative explanations for this positive internment effect, such as occupational change.

My broader research agenda extends this analysis. One work in progress shows that the internment camp locations created new, long-lasting "ethnic enclaves" and reshaped Japanese American population distribution for decades. Another work in progress uses linked census data to build a county-level measure of historical intergenerational mobility. I will use this to estimate the economic returns of migration from low- to high-opportunity areas across the United States during the early Twentieth Century.

My research demonstrates my ability to use my skillset of causal inference, quasi-experimental, and large-scale panel data methods to answer questions at the heart of labor economics and migration.